2.3 Trade Expands

Just as the Renaissance spurred an expansion in people's thoughts and attitudes, it also inspired a spirit of adventure and curiosity about the world. Sea voyagers set out to explore new lands and, above all, to find new trading opportunities and markets.

MAIN IDEA New sea routes and developments in sailing technology allowed for an expansion of trade between European societies and the East.

EXPANDING TRADE WITH ASIA

In the mid-15th century, the Turks of the Ottoman Empire captured the city of Constantinople. Located on a peninsula between Europe and Asia, Constantinople joined the two continents. Capturing the city gave the Turks complete control of the land trade routes that connected the continents. This control allowed the Turks to charge Europeans high prices for Asian goods. Turkish merchants could then make a **profit**, or earn more money than they spent, on the goods.

To avoid trading with the Turks over land, Europeans explored new sea routes to Asia. At the end of the 15th century, Portuguese navigator **Vasco da Gama** sailed to India via one of these routes. He and his fleet traveled around the Cape of Good Hope at the southern tip of Africa. Portuguese navigator **Bartholomeu Dias** had first discovered this route about a decade earlier. Da Gama was able to return from his trip with Indian spices. This journey helped reestablish direct trade between Europe and the East.

PORTUGAL AND AFRICA

In the early 1400s, **Prince Henry the Navigator** established a school on the Atlantic coast in Sagres, Portugal. The school consisted of mathematicians, mapmakers, astronomers, instrument makers, and other instructors who taught students about sailing. Henry's goal was to train sailors about shipbuilding and **navigation**, or planning and following a route. He wanted to send his students on ocean explorations.

Students learned, among other lessons, how to build a special new ship called a **caravel**. The caravel was a light sailing ship that was both quick and able to sail windward, or into the wind. These characteristics made the ship a particularly good choice for the long voyages Henry had in mind.

Caravels made it possible for explorers to sail farther down the West African coast—and elsewhere. Even Christopher Columbus used two caravels during his historic voyage to the Americas in 1492. In the 1420s, Henry began funding caravel expeditions to Africa. Though Henry himself never joined these expeditions, he instructed his sailors to return with goods from Africa's western coast. During part of the Middle Ages, Portugal was under Islamic rule, and Muslim traders had long told stories about a "land of gold" near the African coast. A series of powerful African empires had inspired these stories. And the stories weren't that far from the truth.

HISTORICAL THINKING

1. **READING CHECK** What was the new sea route that Bartholomeu Dias first discovered and Vasco da Gama later followed to get to India?
2. **ANALYZE CAUSE AND EFFECT** Why did Europeans want to find new sea routes to Asia in the 15th century?
3. **EVALUATE** What might have been some of the advantages and disadvantages of taking a long voyage in a caravel?

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CRITICAL VIEWING This sculpture in Lisbon, Portugal, called *Monument to the Discoveries,* celebrates the voyages of Portuguese explorers of the 15th and 16th centuries. Henry the Navigator stands at the top part of the monument, which is shaped like the front of a ship. Behind him are explorers, mapmakers, and others who played an important role in early exploration. Why is the monument's setting a fitting choice?

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